

Tanishq, Fabindia and Lenskart learnt this the hard way. Tanishq, for instance, meant to celebrate the idea of communal harmony by showcasing a Muslim family organising a baby shower for their Hindu daughter-in-law.

The idea did not go down well with a set of customers who saw it as an effort to legitimise the alleged phenomenon of love *jihad*, and called for the brand's boycott.

Love *jihad* is a controversial term used by some groups to allege a conspiracy that Muslim men target women from other faiths, especially Hindus, for marriage.

Likewise, in the case of FabIndia's *Jashn-e-Riwaaz* campaign, critics said the use of an Urdu phrase for a Hindu festival was an attempt at the Abrahamisation of Indian traditions, or modification of Hindu tenets to incorporate characteristics of other faiths.

Target enraged a large section of conservative customers who saw it as an ideological overreach.

REPUTATIONAL HIT

Lenskart received intense criticism online and triggered protests in its physical stores. Its detractors saw the grooming guidelines as hypocrisy; its alleged discriminatory work culture showed that its carefully crafted image of a progressive brand was a sham, they said.

Company reputations are particularly vulnerable to controversies of the kind highlighted above.

Employer branding is an integral part of a brand's vitality, says Harish Bijoor, founder of Harish Bijoor Consults, a brand strategy firm based in Bengaluru. "Good employer branding is not mere cosmetics, it has reputational as well as financial repercussions," he adds.

Indeed, a sense of disengagement sets in if employees don't feel heard



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SANDEEP GOYAL

CHAIRMAN,
REDIFFUSION



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or respected or their religious identity or personal safety is under attack. A dent in employer branding makes it difficult to attract fresh talent, too.

DOING IT RIGHT

Of course, promoting a cause is not universally a bad idea. When the cause is in consonance with the brand's personality, it becomes a strategy and when it is not, it's a stretch that eventually gives way.

Detergent brand Ariel ran a successful campaign in which it urged men to "share the load" of household chores—such as washing clothes with women. The campaign resonated with its target customers, women, and didn't have the other party—men—up in arms either because in modern households where women go to work, sharing household chores is a necessity.

Tata Tea's *Jaago Re* campaign is another example of a cause compatible with the brand's personal traits. Bijoor, who was part of the team that orchestrated the campaign, says it was an idea that went beyond the traditional route of advertising a product's features or its goodness and tried to foster social awakening by taking up issues such as corruption, women empowerment, voting rights and climate change.

Jaago Re was a tagline with a natural connection with a tea brand as well as the rampant social issues of that time. "There is, however, a time and place for everything. What worked then may not work today," cautions Bijoor.

Experts say that in today's super-charged and sensitive environment, brands not only need to have a strong compliance framework but also contextual empathy towards external as well as internal stakeholders.

"Brand custodians need to master the art, science and philosophy of walking on eggshells," says Bijoor. **BT**